GEMS OF INDIA

UTSAH (UNIVERSAL TEAM FOR SOCIAL ACTION AND HELP), *Guwahati*

Key person: **Miguel Das Queah,** Founder
Year of inception: **2011**

GUARDIAN ANGEL OF MINORS

Miguel Das Queah has helped many a child in Assam overcome their fear and speak up against sexual abuse by enabling a safe, child-friendly policing environment

By **HRIJOY DAS KANUNGO**



NILOTPAL BARUAH

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **Since 2013, 300 child sexual abuse survivors have received end-to-end support, from FIR registration to investigation and trial**
- **300 POCSO cases were legally supported, leading to arrests in all cases and 50 convictions**
- **3,000+ police personnel have been trained under the Assam Police Sishu Mitra Programme on child-related laws, child-friendly procedures and investigation protocols**

As a young graduate in 2008, Miguel Das Queah found the answer to the social stigma and systemic injustice around him in a question, posed to him by then president A.P.J. Abdul Kalam at an interaction. As he ranted about all that was wrong in the country, Kalam asked him, "What can you do to make it right? Do you have a plan?" Miguel did not. Kalam's advice—"Go out and do things. You'll figure it out"—became his North Star.

Miguel's initial plan was to start an NGO in Delhi focused on youth issues. That changed when at an event at an old age home in Guwahati, he met celebrated litterateur Mamoni Raisom Goswami, who asked him what he was doing in Delhi. Her words—"If you can't clean your own courtyard, you can't clean the world"—stuck with him.

Miguel did start in his own courtyard—Hafiz Nagar, a slum near his home in Guwahati. In his conversations with residents, he found that while the adults spoke of abuse, low wages and hardship, the children were mostly silent. It alarmed him. Having been a survivor of child sexual abuse, Miguel realised that children often lack the language, space or safety to express their problems.